[redacted]

To the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters,

Thank you for the opportunity to make a submission to this important inquiry.

I understand that as per the terms of reference for this inquiry that the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters (JSCEM) will be looking into a number of areas. In this submission, I am advocating for changes to the conduct and operation at polling booths and the composition of the Parliament.

Conduct and operation at Polling Booths.

Unfortunately, the 2025 election in Chisholm saw voter intimidation and harassment of candidates and volunteers at voting booths. Excessive numbers of volunteers who did not respect voters' personal space and their wish to not be canvassed became an issue during pre-poll and continued until the voting period closed, and this was behaviour witnessed largely from the [redacted] Party. The use of loudspeakers by the [redacted] Party to canvass in breach of the Commonwealth Electoral Act (1918) and of unauthorised signage by third parties were regularly reported to the Australian Electoral Commission (AEC). In some instances, it was possible for the AEC to quickly resolve issues, but this was not always the case.

It should deeply concern anyone who cares about democracy that such behaviour became normalised during the 2025 election, and steps should be taken to ensure this doesn't happen again. Voters and volunteers should never be intimidated and indeed should be encouraged to participate in our democracy.

Recommendations:

1. Limit the number of volunteers and signs each registered political party can use at each booth and ban the use of bunting. This is consistent with electoral laws in a number of jurisdictions, including in Victoria which is my home state.
2. More AEC staff on booths to enforce laws.
3. Faster resolution processes when there are allegations and/or disputes regarding conduct on booths.

Composition of the Parliament.

In Victoria, we have been subject to a number of redistributions over the last decade due to shifts in population growth. It is of course appropriate that the AEC, as the independent electoral commission, be responsible for boundary changes, but constituents report that the changes have been excessive. Suburbs are regularly divided, community organisations are moved across boundaries, and I have heard that it makes it more difficult for people to build relationships with their representatives and advocate for community interests and infrastructure. It seems that there should be more stability for voters so they can a) feel part of a community b) be able to build relationships with their elected representatives over a long period of time and c) advocate for their interests in a consistent and predictable fashion.

[redacted]

In submissions made to the AEC ahead of the finalised redistribution, it was noted that the proposed changes split suburbs and communities, did not necessarily reflect communities of interest and did not necessarily use natural boundaries to determine the changes to the electorate. Whilst the constraints the AEC must use to determine boundaries are well understood in order to preserve numbers of voters within seats within the state, there is a sense that there must be greater regard to communities and their interests.

Additionally, the growth of electorates has been unequal over Australia, with the number of electors per seat also being unequal across the country. Since the last parliament expansion in 1984, electorates contained approximately 75,000 voters and is now around 134,000 voters. Somewhat perversely, in 2025 Victoria is represented by one less seat (38) that it was in 1984 (39) when the parliament last expanded despite the significant population growth in the state. The ratio of voters to representative limits the ability for all voters to easily access their representatives, and this remains quite unequal across state and territory lines in Australia. There should be a smaller number of voters to representatives as a ratio, and this should be more consistent across the country.

Recommendations:

4. Consider expanding the parliament to ensure a) a smaller ratio of voters to representatives and b) consistency in this ratio across the country.
5. Examine the factors that trigger a redistribution and consider measures that better balance consistency and stability of electorates with the need to change boundaries based on population changes.

Once again, I thank JSCEM for the opportunity to make this submission and for your consideration of the recommendations provided.

I would welcome the opportunity to provide evidence as a witness in a hearing, should the committee require this.

Your Sincerely,

[redacted]